

How to Secure and Govern Microsoft 365 Copilot and Agents at Scale

Max Goss



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a Live Interactive Poll**

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How confident are you in your organization's ability to manage the security and governance risks associated with Microsoft 365 Copilot and Copilot Agents?

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How confident are you in your organization's ability to manage the security and governance risks associated with Microsoft 365 Copilot and Copilot Agents?

KEEP THIS BOX
Single-Select

1. Very confident — We understand all the risks and have the tools and processes in place to mitigate
2. Somewhat confident — We have some processes in place, but there are gaps in our security/governance controls
3. Not so confident — We have significant gaps in our ability to implement the right security/governance controls
4. Not at all confident — We lack the visibility to identify the risks — let alone to mitigate them
5. Don't know/Not sure

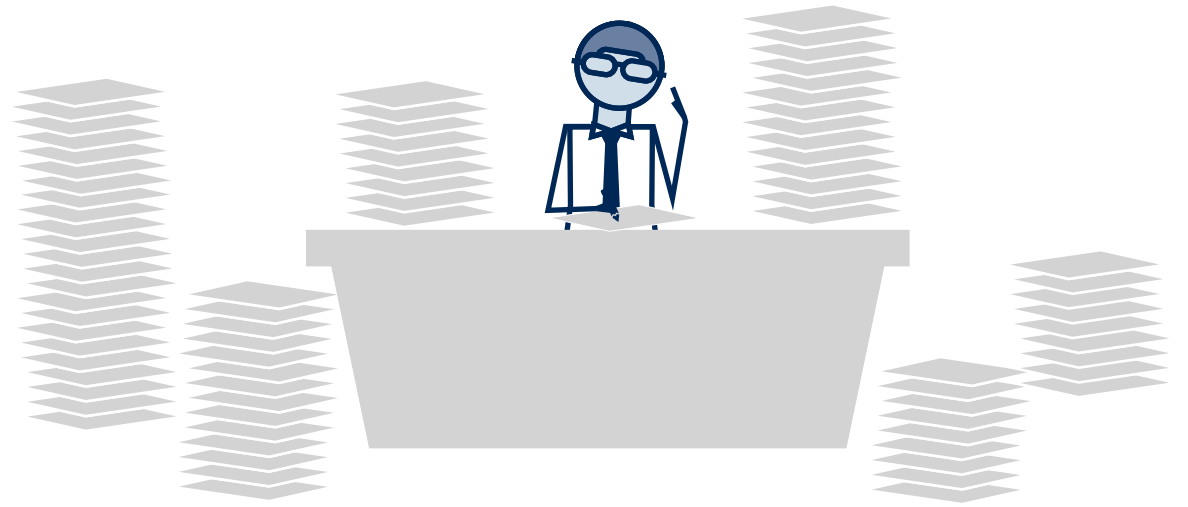
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Problem Space

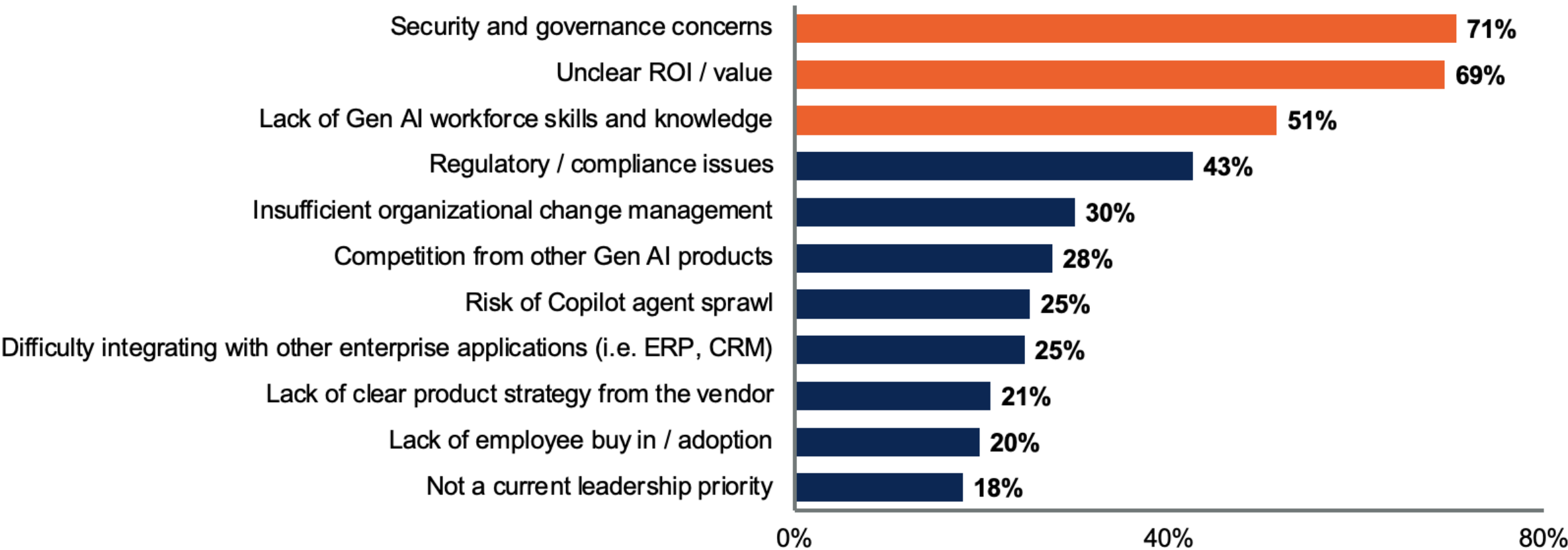
Microsoft 365 Copilot promises a radical shift in terms of how users find, create, consume and understand content.

However, its impact and value are highly dependent on the quality of information stored in Microsoft 365 and the controls in place to protect it.



Security and Governance Concerns Biggest Challenge to Deploying M365 Copilot

Biggest Challenges to Deploying M365 Copilot (Sum of Top 4)

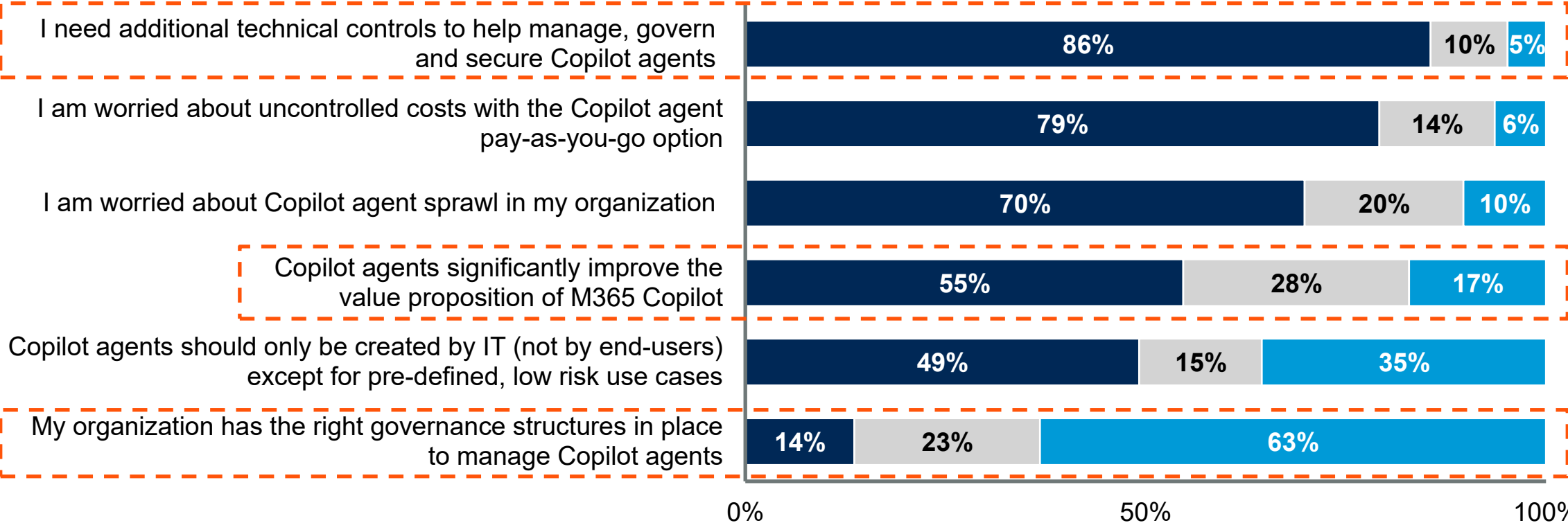


n = 167; respondents who are planning to pilot, already piloted or rolled out M365 Copilot (Q09a), excluding “don't know”
Q: Which of the following have been/are you expecting to be the biggest challenges/obstacles to deploying Microsoft 365 Copilot?
Source: 2025 Gartner Microsoft 365 and Copilot Survey

Copilot Agent Governance Is a Significant Challenge for Many Organizations

Percentage of Respondents

Agree Neither agree nor disagree Disagree



n = 117 - 125; respondents who have either piloted or rolled out M365 Copilot, excluding “don’t know”

Q: To what extent do you agree with the following statements on Copilot agents?

Source: 2025 Gartner Microsoft 365 and Copilot Survey

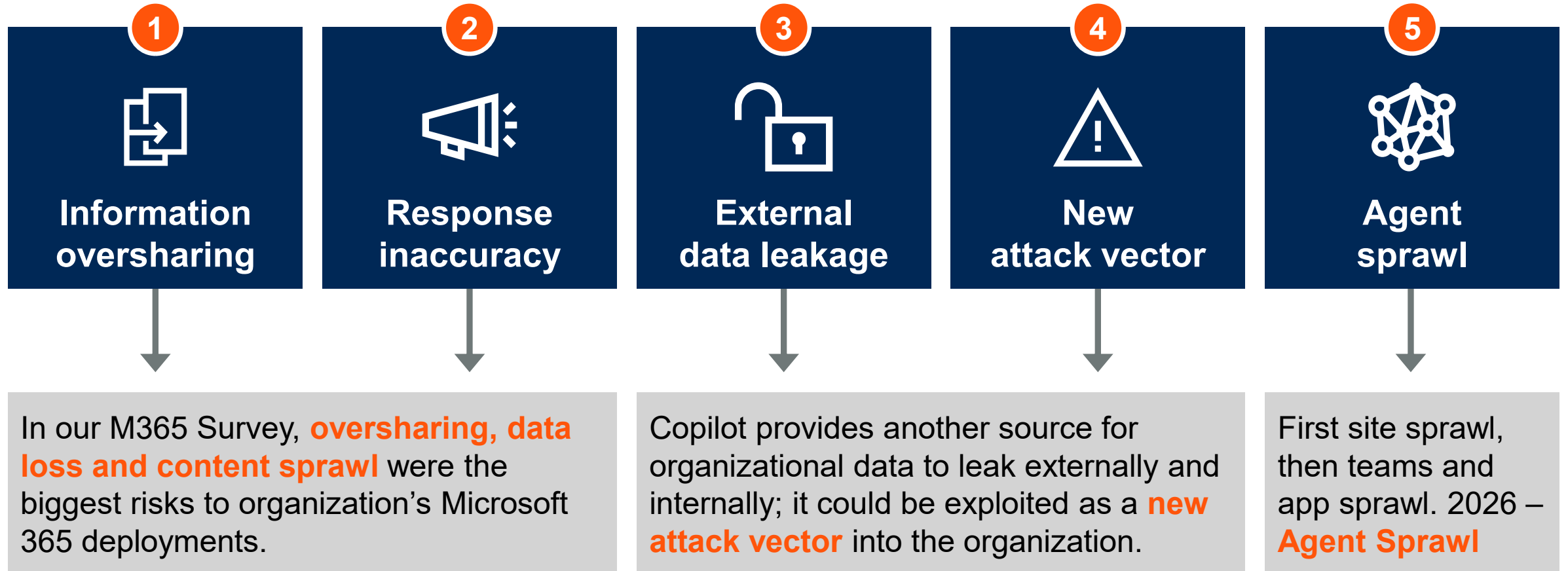


56% of organizations said their top approach to mitigating risk was to limit their AI rollout to low-risk and trusted users.

n = 152

Source: 2024 Impact of Gen AI in the Digital Workplace

5 Leading M365 Copilot Risks





Examples



Oversharing/Exposure of Sensitive Information

What documents is Sebastian Kempf working on?

Sebastian Kempf is currently working on two documents:

- Tennis Club Society.docx, last modified on December 6th, 2023.
- Confidential Salary Structure.docx, also last modified on December 6th, 2023, which includes a salary justification for First Line Agents with a detailed rationale behind the salary offer.

 Copy

● 1 of 30 responses

AI-generated content may be incorrect



Oversharing/Exposure of Sensitive Information

What was the salary offer?

The document titled "Confidential Salary Structure" authored by [Sebastian Kempf](#) mentions that the salary offer for first line agents is **30,000 GBP per annum**. This offer is said to be aligned with the company's budget, goals, and strategy, and reflects the company's commitment to invest in its human capital and reward its employees for their contributions and achievements. ¹



Confidential Salary Structure

SharePoint: Seb's public team > ... > General

Sebastian Kempf modified on 12/6/2023

Reference

1



Confidential Salary ...



Copy



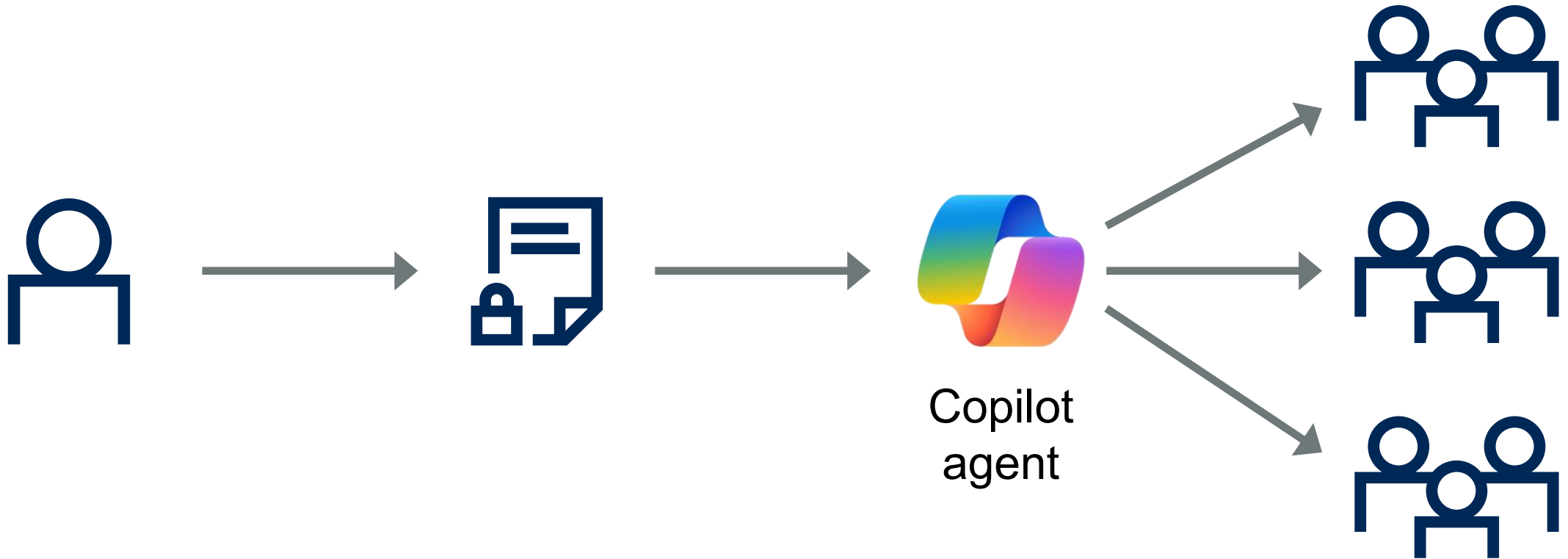
2 of 30 responses

AI-generated content may be incorrect

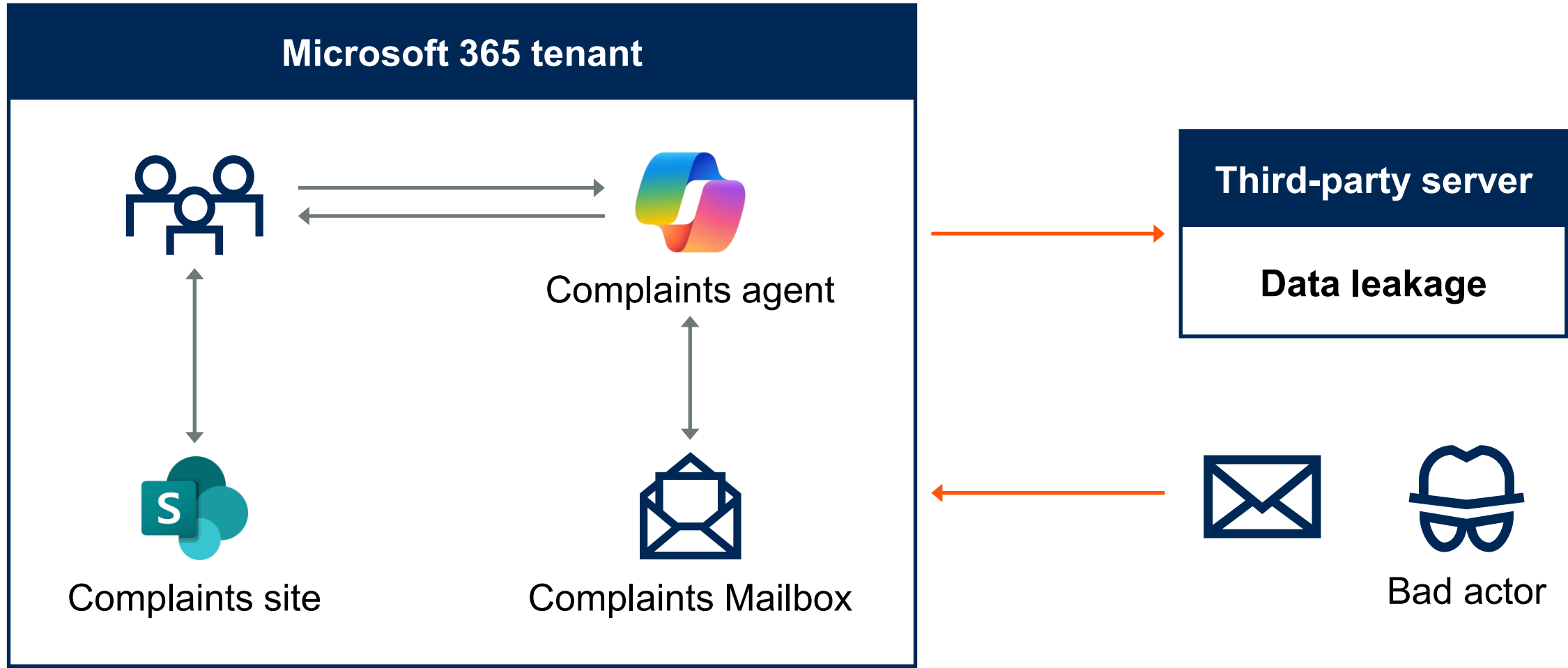


Source: Microsoft 365 Copilot

Oversharing 2.0: Human-to-Agent and Agent-to-Agent Sharing



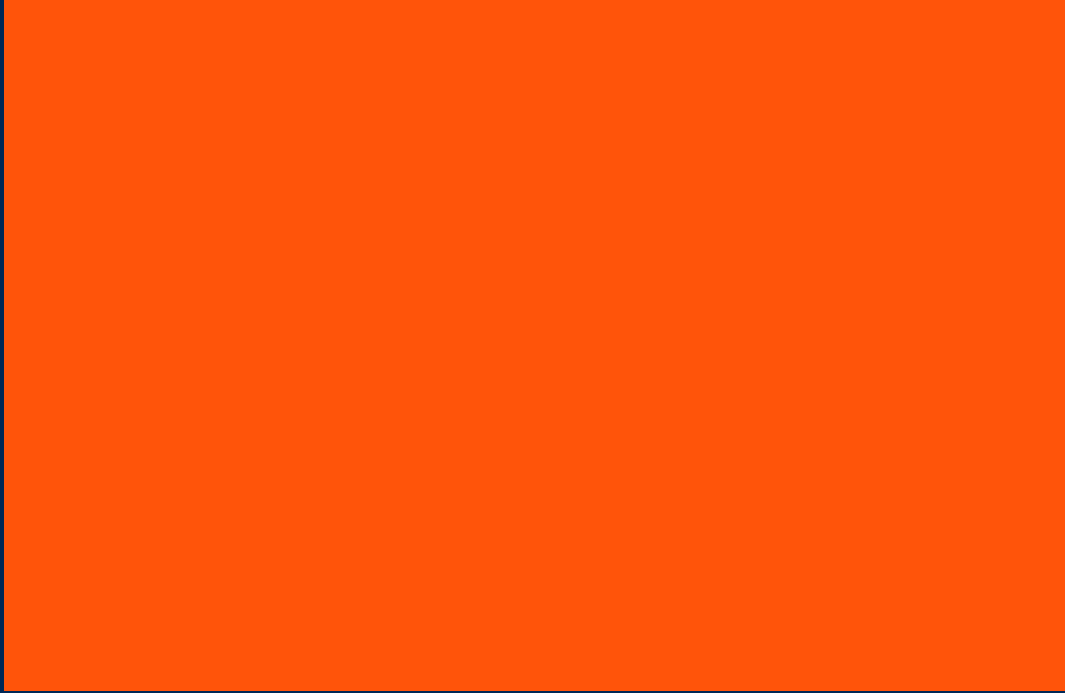
Agents Could Also Present a New Attack Vector Into the Organization



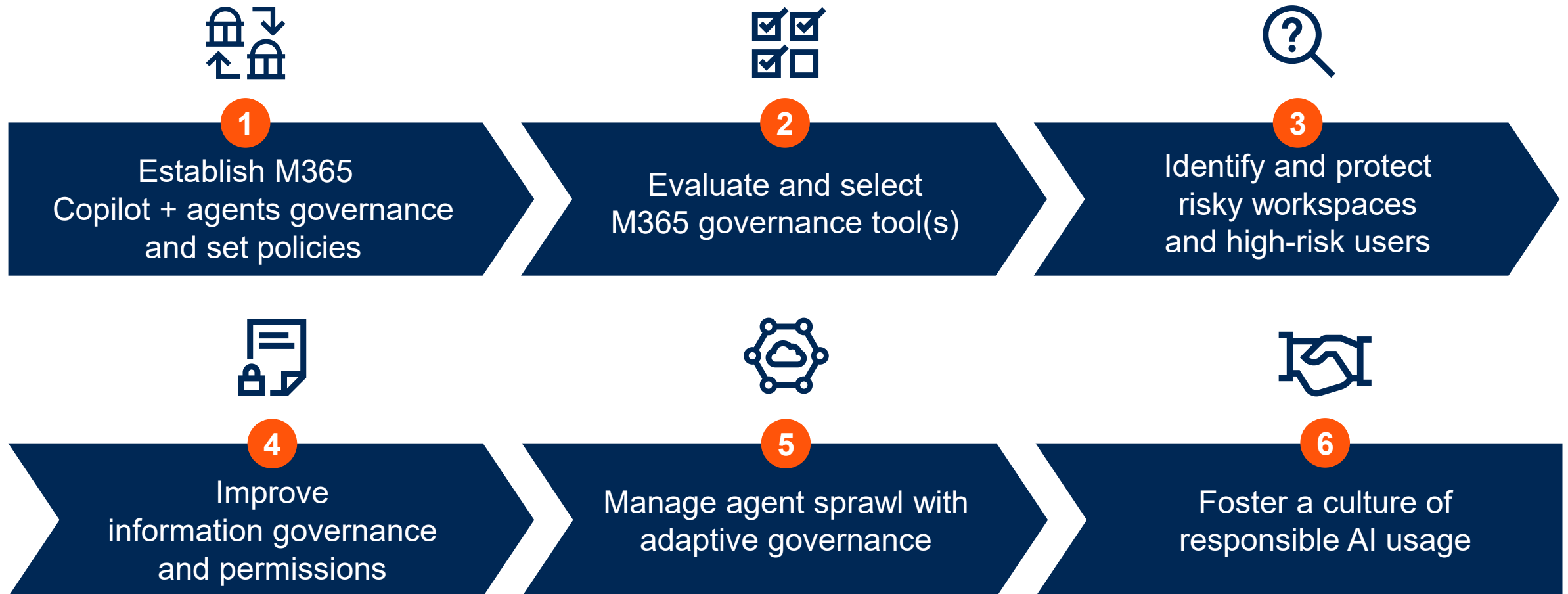
Source: Gartner



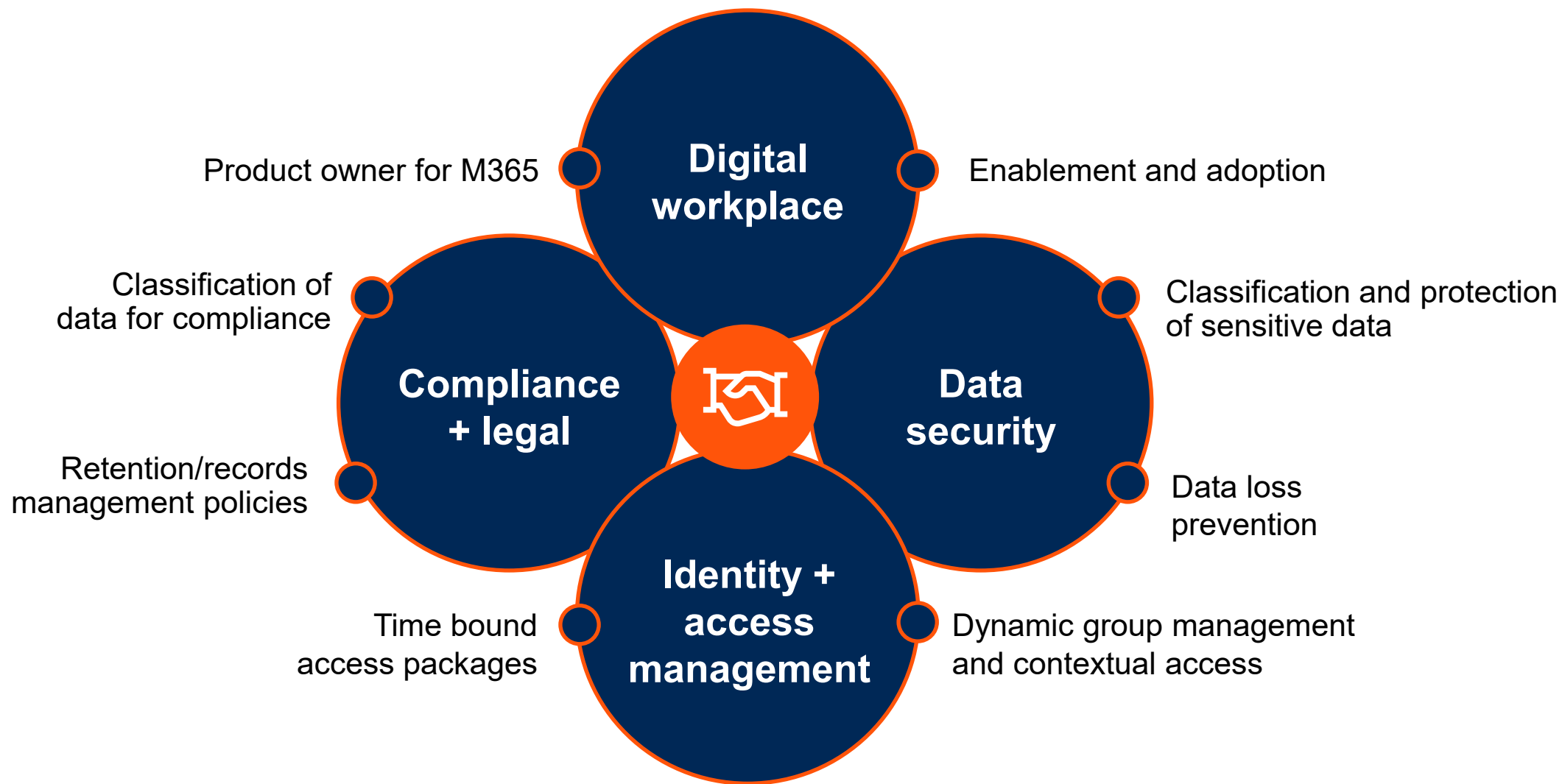
Framework for Securing and Governing M365 Copilot



Six Steps to Secure and Govern Microsoft 365 Copilot + Agents at Scale



1 Establish Cross-Functional M365 Governance



Agree on M365 Copilot Policies

-  **1** Acceptable usage policy
-  **2** Meeting recordings and transcription
-  **3** Bing web search
-  **4** Copilot agents and plug-ins
-  **5** Retention of Copilot interactions

2 Evaluate and Select M365 Governance Tool(s)

Despite recent improvements there are still gaps in the Microsoft 365 native controls (particularly with E3) and with well over 100 admin centers, visibility as well as managing Microsoft 365 at scale is a problem ...

First party

Microsoft Purview

- Data protection / governance

SharePoint Advanced Management (SAM)

- Risky sites report /Site access restrictions
- Site life cycle policies

Agent 365 (May 1st \$15 pupm or with E7)

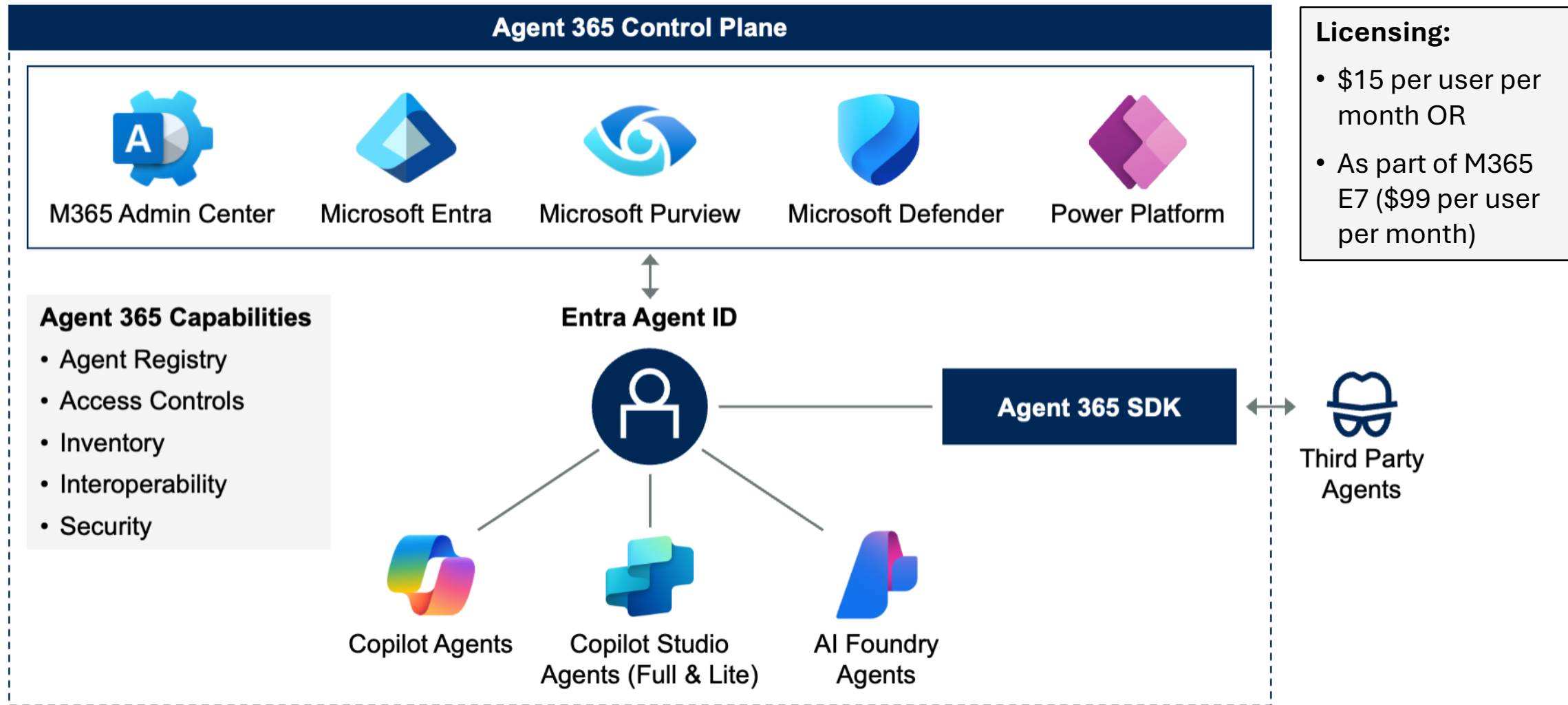
- New Microsoft agent control plane
- Agent registry and governance

Third party

DSPM/M365 management and governance/AI Security Platforms

- Provisioning, monitoring and life cycle controls
- Automated policy engine
- Granular visibility and management of permissions
- AI/Agent runtime controls

Agent 365 — Microsoft Control Plane for Agents



E7 Microsoft's Biggest (and Most Expensive) M365 Bundle yet

M365 E5	M365 Copilot	Agent 365	Entra Suite
• M365 Office Apps • Windows 11 • Intune, Purview, Defender, Entra ID P2	• Microsoft Graph Grounded Enterprise AI assistant • Agent access and no/low code agent builder	• Agent visibility governance and management • Supports first and third party agents	• Identity and network governance solution • Secure web gateway
\$60 per user per month (after July price rise)	\$30 per user per month	\$15 per user per month	\$9 per user per month (with E5)

Microsoft 365 E7

List price \$99 per user per month



Agent 365 is a Promising **Work-in-Progress** with a **Premium Price Tag**

n = 215

Source: 2025 Microsoft 365 and Copilot Survey

Three Different Third-Party Approaches

	Data security vendors	M365 management and governance vendors	AI Security Platform vendors
	BigID, Rubrik, Varonis	AvePoint, eSHARE, Infotechtion, Orchestra, Powell Software, Rencore, Syskit	Cato Networks, F5, Lasso Security, Palo Alto, Pillar Security, Tenable, Zenity
	- Granular data classification and protection (with E3 or E5) - Can protect systems outside of M365 - Close integration with existing Microsoft Purview controls	- Improved visibility and governance of M365 containers for admins and end users - Site templating and provisioning engine - Advanced storage and life cycle policies	- Runtime analytics and protection for Copilot interactions - Improved visibility and governance for Copilot agents/third-party AI tools - Shadow AI discovery
	- Limited site provisioning/ life cycle features - Limited end-user management of M365 containers - Can be a significant investment	- E5 still needed for advanced data protection controls - Policy engines do not run in real time - Limited (but growing) AI-specific controls	- Immature market - Most vendors are startups/have recently acquired startups - E5 still required for data at rest protection/life cycle controls

3 Identify and Protect Risky Workspaces and High-Risk Users

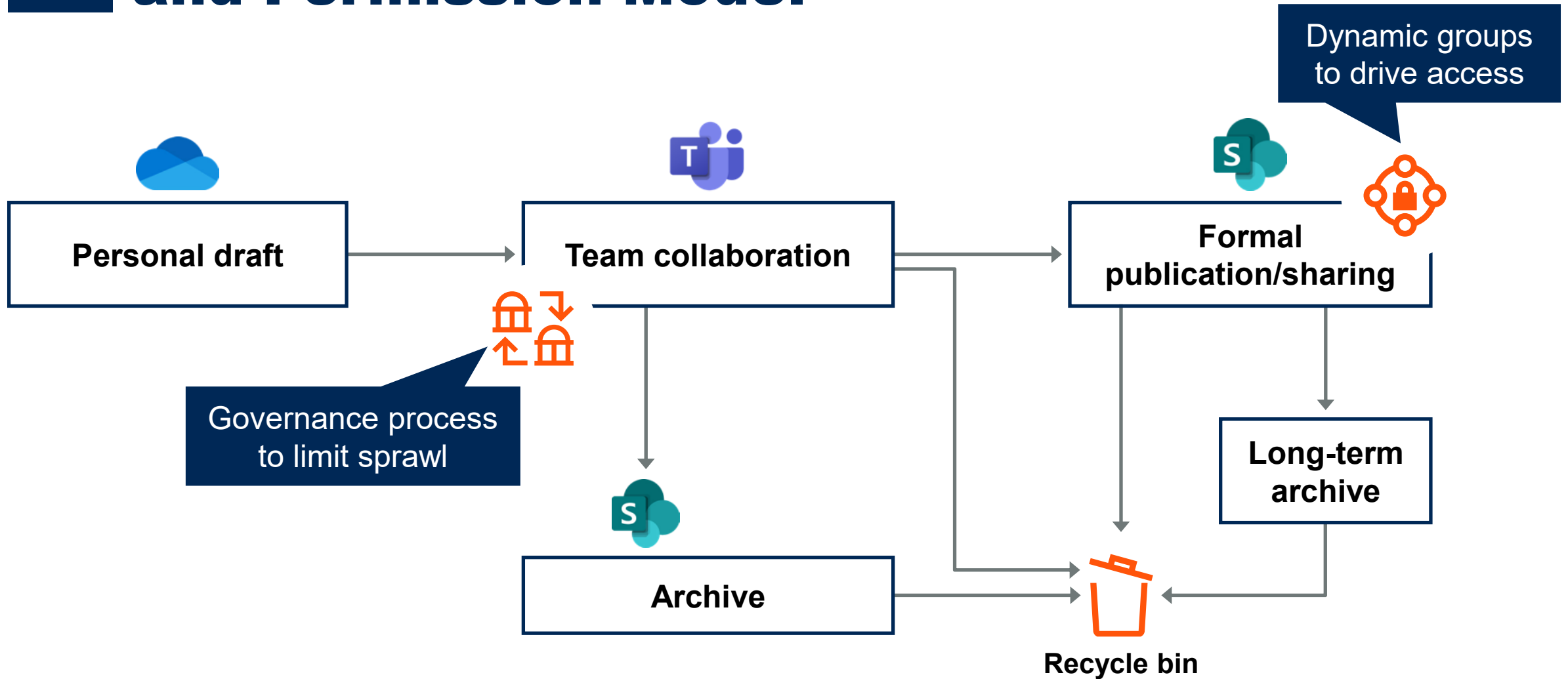
Risky workspaces:

- 1 “Public” groups or teams, or those shared with the “everyone”/all staff groups
- 2 Groups, teams, sites containing lots of unique permissions, or all company links
- 3 Ownerless groups, teams and sites/those with no recent activity

High-risk users/functions

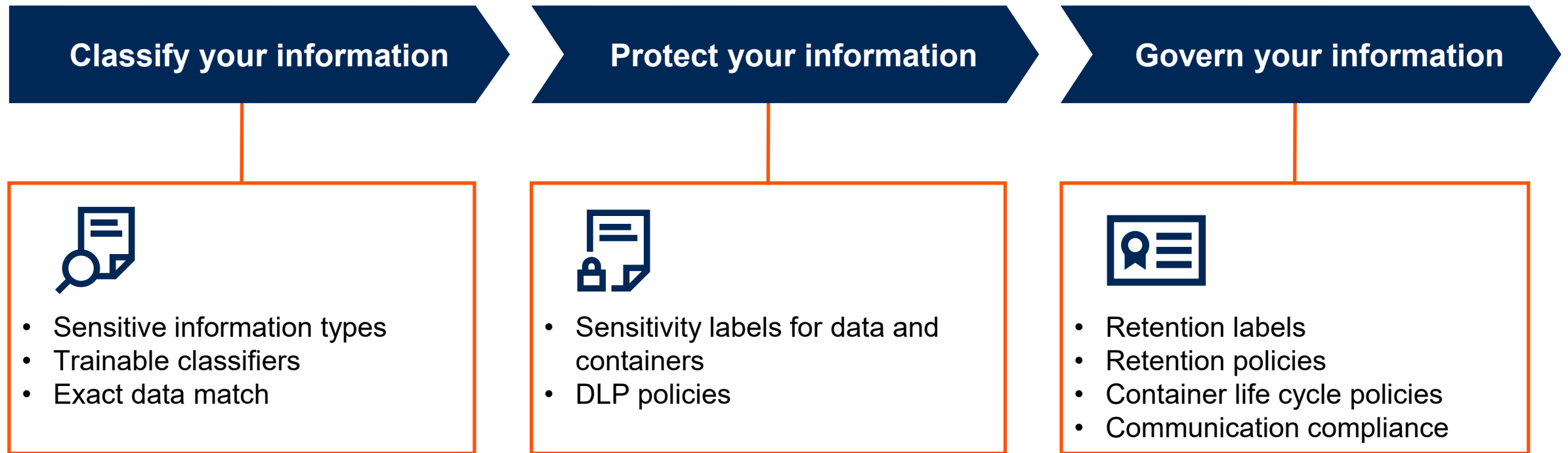
- 1 Executive team, HR, finance etc.
- 2 Parts of the business that must be kept separate e.g., a research department
- 3 Groups that work closely with external users, e.g., through Teams shared channels

4 Improve Information Governance and Permission Model



Implement Information Protection and Retention Policies

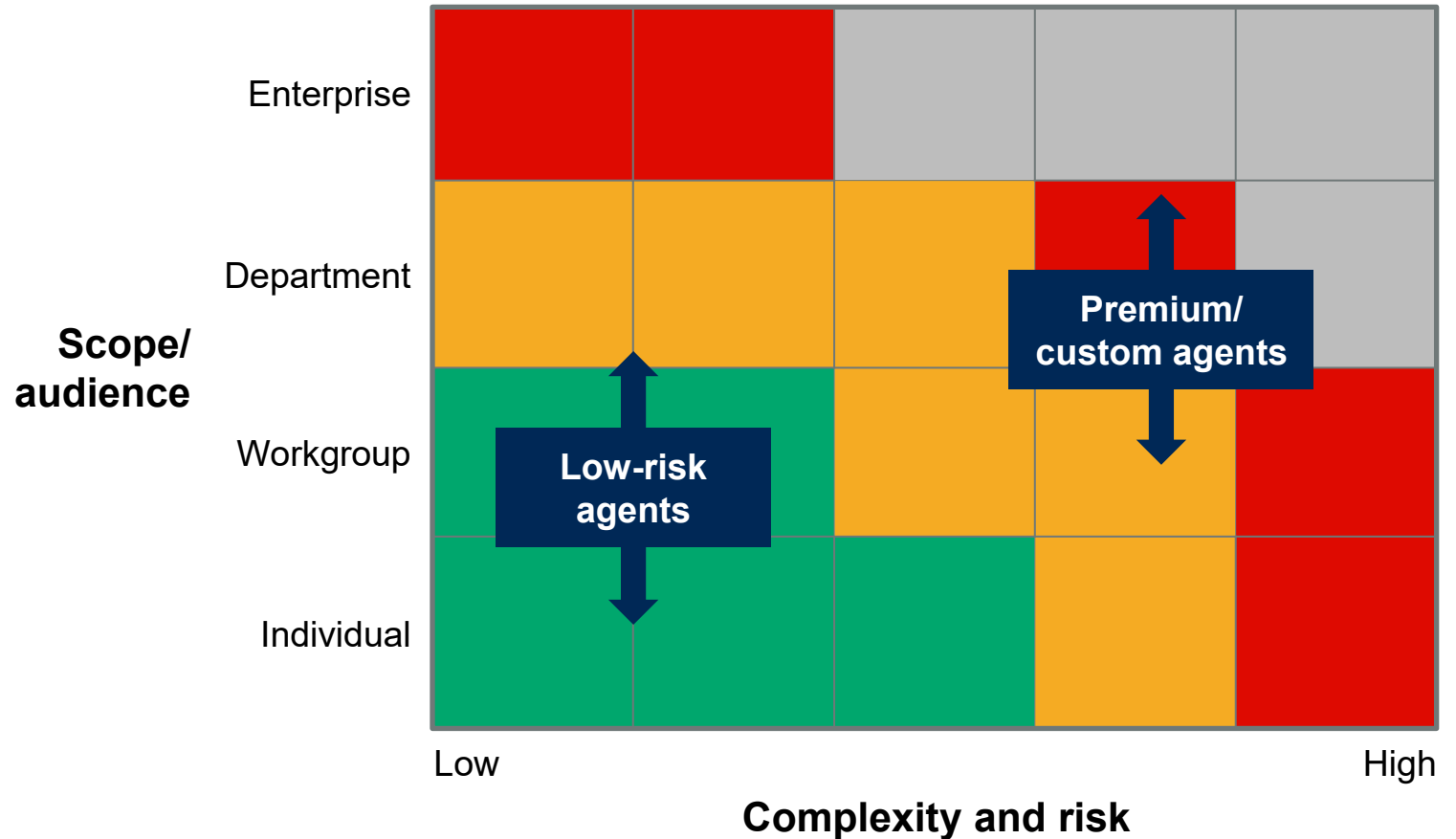
Information protection and retention are two sides of the same coin. Together, they can be used to apply appropriate policies to protect and govern content throughout its life cycle.



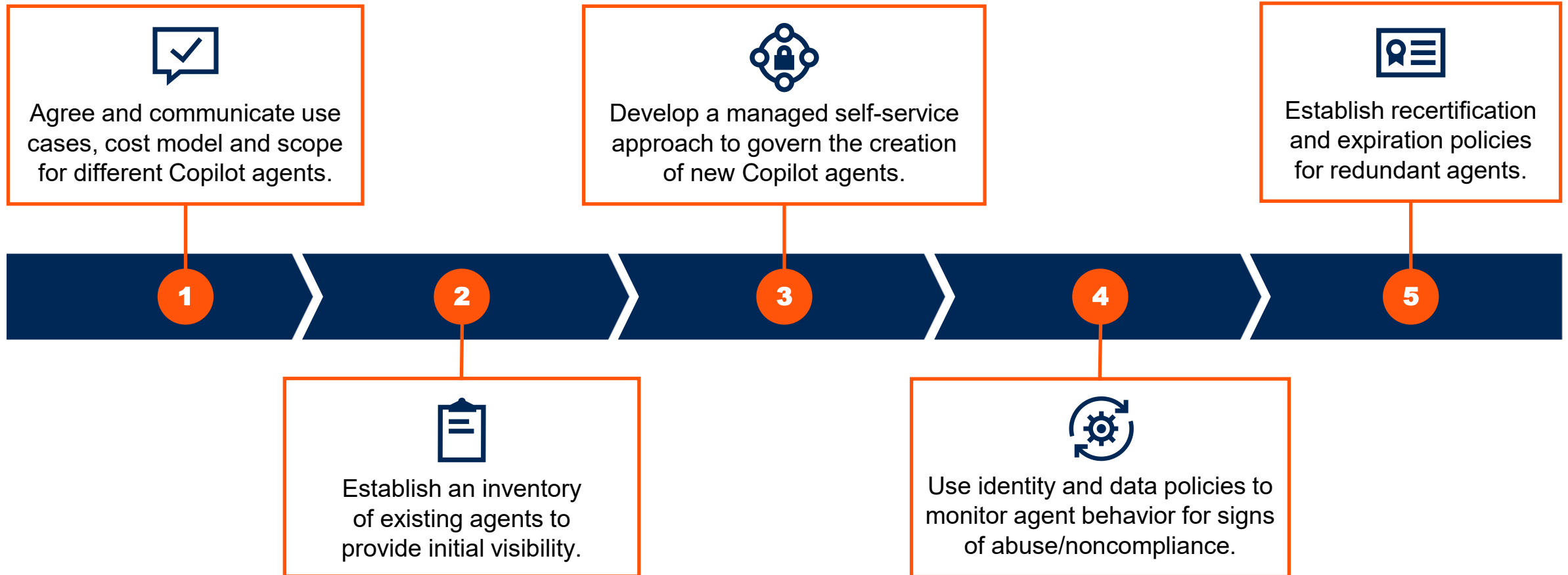
5 Manage Agent Sprawl Through Adaptive Governance

■ **Safe zone:** self-governing “sweet spot” ■ **Supported:** co-create with pro developers and adaptive governance ■ **Danger:** require IT oversight and governance before release ■ **Off limits:** move to IT-owned portfolio

- Scale governance depending on agent risk and complexity.
- Manage risk and costs with DLP and a multienvironment strategy.
- Enforce life cycle management to retire obsolete apps/agents/flows.



Build an End-to-End Agent Life Cycle Framework



6 Foster Responsible AI Culture

Most organizations have mandatory cyber training, but many **do not consider Responsible AI Training**



**Sensitive data
handling**



**Disinformation
security**



**Validation of
AI output**

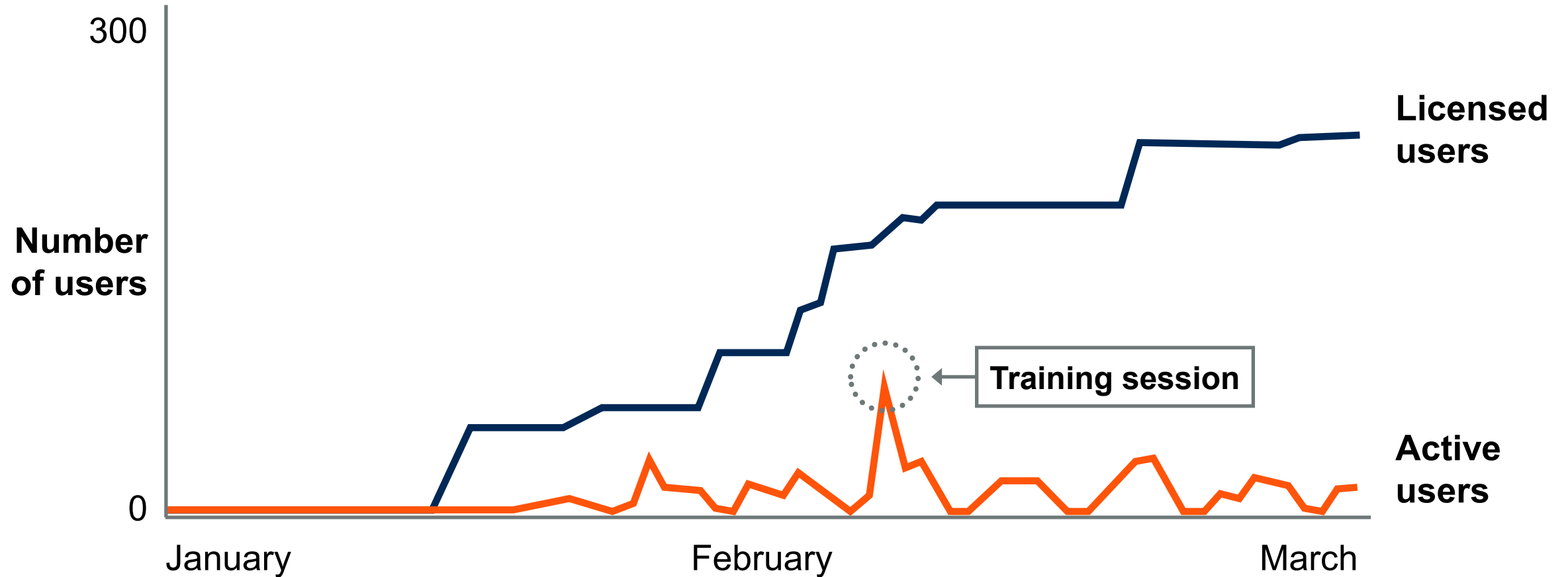


**Human-in-
the-loop**



By 2027: Responsible AI will become just as important as Cyber Security Training.

Treat AI as a Business Transformation — Not Just a Technology Change



Recommendations

- ④ Establish a multidisciplinary approach to M365 Copilot governance, including digital workplace, compliance, identity and security teams.
- ④ Assess first- or third-party add-on products that improve visibility and governance features across Microsoft 365.
- ④ Identify your sensitive information and high-risk users, and leverage data security and identity governance tools to apply protection.
- ④ Build an adaptive governance model to manage the end-to-end life cycle of agents, including registration, ongoing monitoring and disposition.
- ④ Design mandatory responsible AI training to educate employees on how to work safely with AI tools, adopting a “trust but verify” approach.

Recommended Gartner Insights

To learn more about access to Gartner research, expert analyst insight, and peer communities, contact your Gartner representative or click on “Become A Client” on gartner.com to speak with one of our specialists.

- 🔍 [How to Build a Microsoft 365 Copilot and Agents Strategy in 2026](#)
Max Goss, Matt Cain and Dan Wilson
- 🔍 [First Take: Agent 365 a Promising Work in Progress with a Premium Price Tag](#)
Max Goss, Avivah Litan and Others
- 🔍 [How to Secure and Govern Microsoft 365 Copilot at Scale](#)
Max Goss, Avivah Litan and Dan Wilson
- 🔍 [How to Mitigate the Risks of Microsoft 365 Copilot Agent Sprawl](#)
Max Goss, Avivah Litan and Others
- 🔍 [Innovation Insight: Enterprise AI Assistants](#)
Max Goss and Jason Wong

Take our 2026 M365 and Copilot survey

If you are a decision maker for
M365 in your organization, we
would love to hear from you!



https://researchcircles.gartner.com/c/a/62z0SqYrtAx3fnNXZeXyaV?Sample_Type=Open